

Deployment Guide — Vercel

Every step to take BuildList.com from the files in this package to a live site, in the order to do them, and what to watch for at each one.

Stage	What it does	Time
1	Before you start — accounts and what to have ready	15 min
2	Set up the database (Supabase)	20 min
3	Create the first administrator	5 min
4	Load the 618 firms into the database	5 min
5	Put the files on GitHub	10 min
6	Deploy on Vercel and set the environment variables	20 min
7	Connect the portal's Publish button	5 min
8	Point buildlist.com at the site	15 min + DNS
9	Final settings in Supabase	5 min
10	Check everything before announcing	30 min
11	After launch: the first week	ongoing

The one rule that matters most

Supabase gives you two keys. The **anon** key is public and belongs in the browser. The **service_role** key bypasses every security rule in the database. It must only ever go in Vercel's environment variables (marked secret) and in `supabase/.env` on your own computer. Never paste it into a file you upload, a chat, an email or a screenshot. The build refuses to run if it detects the service key used in place of the anon key.

1. Before you start

Create these accounts first. All have free tiers that are enough for launch.

Account	Used for	Where
GitHub	Stores the site's files; Vercel builds from it	github.com
Vercel	Hosts the site and runs the form functions	vercel.com — sign up with GitHub
Supabase	The database, logins and file storage	supabase.com
Resend (optional)	Emails you each form submission	resend.com
Google Analytics (optional)	Site-wide visitor figures	analytics.google.com

Have these to hand

- Access to the DNS settings for buildlist.com (Cloudflare or wherever the domain is managed).
- Your company details: registered address, URSB registration number and URA TIN. They are entered as settings in Stage 6, not typed into the files.
- The phone number the public should call or WhatsApp.
- Node.js installed on your computer (nodejs.org, the LTS version). Needed once, in Stage 4.
- GitHub Desktop (desktop.github.com). The GitHub website's drag-and-drop uploader fails on folders; Desktop does not.

Keep one copy of the project

Unzip the package once, into a folder you will keep, for example Documents\buildlist. Delete older downloads. Two copies of a project is how the wrong file gets edited and uploaded.

2. Set up the database

1. Go to **supabase.com** → **New project**. Choose the region closest to Uganda. Save the database password in a password manager — Supabase shows it once.
2. Open **SQL Editor** → **New query**. Run these files from the supabase folder, one at a time, in this order. Paste the whole file, press Run, and wait for "Success" before the next.

File	What it does	When
schema.sql	Creates every table, the security rules and file storage	Always, first
seed.sql	Loads categories, districts, tiers and ad positions	New database only
PATCH-01.sql	Security fixes for a database created before this version	Only if you set up the database earlier
PATCH-02.sql	Puts the 22 categories right, removes an older duplicate set, and loads what each tier includes	Always — after the two above
seed-ads.sql	Sample campaigns so you can preview the ad slots	Optional — hidden from

File	What it does	When
		visitors
REMOVE-SAMPLES.sql	Deletes those samples when you no longer want them listed	Whenever you like

PATCH-02 is not optional

An earlier version of seed.sql created a second set of categories with different names, which is why the site could show "Quantity Surveyors" and "Quantity Surveying" side by side. PATCH-02 moves any firm filed under an old category to the correct one, deletes the leftovers, and writes what each tier includes into the database. Without it the portal's Tiers page has nothing to show and the site falls back to Free for everyone.

Running schema.sql twice is safe

Every statement checks whether its table or column already exists. If a run stops part-way with an error, fix the cause and run the whole file again — do not try to run only the remaining half.

3. Open **Settings → API**. Copy the **Project URL**, the **anon public** key and the **service_role** key into a password manager. You will need all three.

3. Create the first administrator

Later staff are invited from inside the portal. The very first administrator has to be created by hand, because inviting needs an administrator to already exist.

4. In Supabase: **Authentication → Users → Add user**. Enter your real email, a strong password, and tick **Auto Confirm User**.
5. In the SQL Editor, run this with your own email and name:


```
insert into staff (user_id, role, name, email)
select id, 'admin', 'Your Name', email from auth.users where email =
'you@example.co.ug';
```
6. Run it only once. It takes your user ID straight from the account, so there is nothing to copy and nothing to mistype.

4. Load the firms into the database

7. In the project folder, copy supabase\ .env .example to supabase\ .env. Open it in Notepad and fill in the Project URL and the **service_role** key.
8. Open Command Prompt and run, one line at a time:


```
cd /d "C:\path\to\buildlist-vercel"
node supabase/migrate.js
```
9. It ends with a count for each table. Firms should read 618. Running it again is safe: it updates rather than duplicates.

The .env file never leaves your computer

It holds the service key. .gitignore already stops Git from uploading it, but check before your first push that supabase/.env does not appear in GitHub Desktop's list of changes. If it ever does, stop, and rotate the key in Supabase before doing anything else.

5. Put the files on GitHub

10. In GitHub Desktop: **File → Add local repository** → choose the project folder. When it says it is not a repository, choose **create a repository** there.
11. Look down the list of files it is about to commit. Confirm there is no supabase/.env. Dotfiles such as .gitignore and .vercelignore must be included.
12. Type a summary such as "Initial launch", press **Commit to main**, then **Publish repository**. Keep it private.

6. Deploy on Vercel

13. In Vercel: **Add New → Project** → import the repository. Framework Preset: **Other**. Leave the build and output settings empty; they come from vercel.json.
14. Before pressing Deploy, open **Environment Variables** and add these. Tick **Sensitive** only where the table says so.

Name	Value	Sensitive
SITE_URL	https://buildlist.com	No
SUPABASE_URL	Project URL from Stage 2	No
SUPABASE_ANON_KEY	The anon public key	No
SUPABASE_SERVICE_KEY	The service_role key	YES
CONTACT_PHONE	e.g. +256 772 123456 — shown on the site	No
CONTACT_WHATSAPP	Only if different from the phone	No
COMPANY_ADDRESS	Registered office address	No
COMPANY_URSB_NO	URSB registration number	No
COMPANY_TIN	URA TIN	No
CONTACT_EMAIL	Only if not hello@buildlist.com	No
ADS_EMAIL	Only if not advertising@buildlist.com	No
GA_MEASUREMENT_ID	G-XXXXXXXXXX, if you use Google Analytics	No
RESEND_API_KEY	From resend.com, if you want form emails	YES
FORM_NOTIFY_EMAIL	Where form emails go	No
FORM_WEBHOOK_URL	Slack or Make.com, if you use one	YES

Nothing is shown half-filled

Any company detail you leave unset is simply left out of the site — no brackets, no dummy numbers. Add it

later as a variable and redeploy, and it appears everywhere it belongs: the About page, the privacy policy, and the Call and WhatsApp buttons.

15. Press **Deploy**. The build log should end with lines like:

```
Built 700 pages + sitemap (703 URLs)
site-config.js: database connected, analytics G-XXXXXXXXXX
```

Changing a variable later

Vercel does not apply a changed variable to a site that is already built. After adding or changing one, go to Deployments → the latest → Redeploy.

7. Connect the Publish button

Saving in the portal writes to the database at once. Publishing rebuilds the public site so visitors see the change, about a minute later.

16. Vercel: **Settings → Git → Deploy Hooks**. Name it “portal”, branch main, Create. Copy the URL.

17. Add it as an environment variable named BUILD_HOOK_URL, marked **Sensitive**, then redeploy.

Treat the hook like a password

Anyone holding it can trigger builds until the month’s allowance is used. The portal never sees it: the browser asks the server, and the server checks the person is signed-in staff before firing it.

8. Point buildlist.com at the site

18. Vercel: **Settings → Domains** → add buildlist.com and www.buildlist.com. Vercel shows the DNS records to create.

19. Create exactly those records at your DNS provider.

20. If the domain is on Cloudflare: set each record to **DNS only** (grey cloud), and set SSL/TLS to **Full (strict)**. An orange-cloud record stops Vercel issuing the certificate and shows visitors an error.

21. Wait for Vercel to show both domains as valid. Usually minutes, occasionally a few hours.

9. Final settings in Supabase

22. **Authentication → URL Configuration**. Set Site URL to https://buildlist.com and add https://buildlist.com/portal.html under Redirect URLs.

This is what caused the “cannot connect to localhost” email links

Sign-in and invitation emails send people to the Site URL. If it still says localhost, every emailed link opens a page that does not exist.

23. Sign in to buildlist.com/portal.html. As an administrator you are asked to set up two-factor authentication: scan the code with Google Authenticator or Microsoft Authenticator and enter the six digits.

24. Only once you are enrolled: open PATCH-01.sql, uncomment the two policies at the end that require a second factor for advertising and staff changes, and run it. Doing this before you enrol locks you out of those controls.

10. Check everything before announcing

Do these on the live address, on a phone as well as a computer.

Check	What you should see
Homepage	LIVE, the quarter and today's date centred in the top strip; twelve category buttons
Directory	All 22 categories; the ad column down the right on a wide screen
A firm profile	Paid tiers show WhatsApp; Free shows Call. Change a tier in the portal, Publish, and it changes
Every form	Submit one of each of the 13. Each must arrive by email, webhook or in the submissions table
Privacy and Terms	Your company details appear; nothing in square brackets
Portal → Publish	Make a small edit, Publish, and see it on the site a minute later
Portal → Staff	Invite a colleague; they receive an email and set their own password
Advert slots	Unsold slots read "Advertisement slot available". Add ?preview to the address to see the samples
A firm profile → Reviews	Write one. It should not appear until you publish it in the portal
Portal → Reviews	Publish it, Publish the site, then find it on the profile
Categories	Each count in the directory matches the number of firms you get when you click it

Sample campaigns

The sample ads from seed-ads.sql never appear to visitors. When you no longer want them listed in the portal, run supabase/REMOVE-SAMPLES.sql.

11. After launch: the first week

The free Supabase plan pauses after 7 days without activity

The public site keeps working, because it is built from files. The portal stops until someone restores the project in Supabase. Daily use prevents it; a holiday does not. Move to the paid plan before staff depend on the portal.

- **Removal requests** promise action within 48 hours. Check them daily; they arrive marked "REMOVAL REQUEST — 48 HOURS".
- **Listing claims**: ring the number already on the listing, never the one on the claim, before approving.
- **Prices**: update weekly from the same suppliers so the series stays comparable, and Publish.
- **Backups**: Supabase → Database → Backups. On the free plan, download one weekly.

- **Analytics:** after 30 days, sort the portal's per-listing table by contacts. Free firms with several contacts are your first sales calls.
- **Reviews:** publish negative ones. Rejecting a fair review to please a paying firm is the one thing that would make every rating on the site worthless.
- **Lead alerts:** each quotation request arrives with a list of the firms whose tier includes lead alerts in that category. Forward it to them the same day — that is the whole product.
- **Monthly reports:** Portal → Analytics lists the firms owed one. Open each, print to PDF, and send it.

What was and was not tested before this was written

So you know where to look first if something behaves unexpectedly.

Tested	How
The site and the portal	Automated checks run in a real browser on every page
All 13 forms	Each posted to the real handler and accepted; an unknown form is refused
Tier privileges	Checked capability by capability, from Free to Platinum
Reviews	Validation, one-per-person, and the moderation queue, against a mock database
Staff invitations	Refused for a missing token, a forged token and an editor
NOT run: the SQL files	No PostgreSQL was available where these were written. They are checked for structure and are safe to run twice, but Supabase is the first place they truly execute — run them one at a time and read each result
NOT tested: live email	Resend, webhooks and DNS can only be proved on your own accounts

If something goes wrong

Symptom	Cause and fix
Build fails: "REFUSING TO BUILD"	The service key was put in SUPABASE_ANON_KEY. Replace it with the anon key and redeploy
Portal says "Not connected to a database"	SUPABASE_URL or SUPABASE_ANON_KEY is missing, or you did not redeploy after adding them
Signed in but the portal shows nothing	No staff row for that login. Repeat Stage 3 with the same email you signed in with
Emailed link opens localhost	Site URL in Supabase still points at localhost. See Stage 9
A form says it did not send	Check Vercel → Logs for the function. Usually no delivery target set: add Supabase, Resend or a webhook
Publish says nothing is configured	BUILD_HOOK_URL is missing, or you did not redeploy after adding it
migrate.js: duplicate key	You are running an older copy. Use the one from this package
Domain shows a certificate error	Cloudflare proxy is on. Set the records to DNS only (grey cloud)
Changes not visible after Publish	Allow a minute, then hard-refresh with Ctrl+Shift+R

Symptom	Cause and fix
Two similar categories listed	PATCH-02 has not been run. See Stage 2
Every firm looks like Free tier	The tiers have no capabilities in the database. Run PATCH-02
A review does not appear	It is waiting in Portal → Reviews, or it was published but the site has not been rebuilt since